

How International Players Have Transformed the NBA

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Introduction

The NBA has undergone a dramatic transformation over the past two decades. Once dominated almost exclusively by American players, the league has seen an accelerating influx of international players that not only excel individually but shifted the NBA's playstyle as a whole. Think Giannis Antetokounmpo, Luka Doncic, and Nikola Jokic. This project aims to quantify the international impact on the NBA and determine whether international players have historically been undervalued in the draft relative to their eventual contributions. To come up with an answer, we will combine player nationality data, draft history, and performance metrics from 2010-2025 to visualize just how good the rest of the world has gotten at basketball.

Source 1 - Wikipedia: List of Players Born Outside the United States (BeautifulSoup, requests)

Wikipedia maintains a comprehensive list of every NBA player born outside of the United States, organized by country of origin. This page will be scraped using BeautifulSoup and the requests library to extract player names, countries of origin, and active seasons, which will then be cross-referenced with stats from the other two sources for draft position data and advanced metrics.

https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/List_of_NBA_players_born_outside_the_United_States

Source 2 - NBA Draft History by Year (pandas.read_html)

Basketball-Reference publishes full draft results for every NBA draft, including each player's draft position, team they were drafted to, college, and early career stats. Draft tables for the years 2010-2025 will be extracted using pandas.read_html() by looping over season-specific URLs for these data categories. Nationality is not directly listed, so player nationality will be cross-referenced from Source 1 by joining on player name. Source 2 therefore contributes draft position and draft year to the integrated dataset, enabling analysis of whether international players are drafted earlier or later compared to their domestic counterparts.

https://www.basketball-reference.com/draft/NBA_2025.html

Source 3 - NBA Advanced Player Stats (nba_api Python Library)

Github has an nba_api library that provides access to [nba.com](https://www.nba.com)'s official data, containing advanced performance metrics for all players across the study period (2010-2025), including Player Efficiency Rating (PER), Win shares, Box Plus/Minus (BPM), True Shooting percentage (TS%), and Value Over Replacement Player (VORP). These enable a rigorous apples-to-apples comparison of international vs. domestic player contribution, controlling for playing time and era.

https://github.com/swar/nba_api (pip install nba_api)

Data Integration and Analysis Plan

All three sources will be joined on player name and season year to produce a unified dataset containing each player's nationality, draft position, and advanced performance metrics. Based

on this data, I hope to answer the questions:

- Which countries have contributed the most NBA players since 2010?
- Are international players undervalued in the draft? Has that changed?
- Has the NBA's style of play shifted as the share of international players has grown?

Visualizations will include a time-series chart on international player share by season, scatter plots comparing advanced stats of domestic and international players, and a year-by-year comparison of playing style metrics such as three-point rate, pace, and assist rate as international representation has grown.